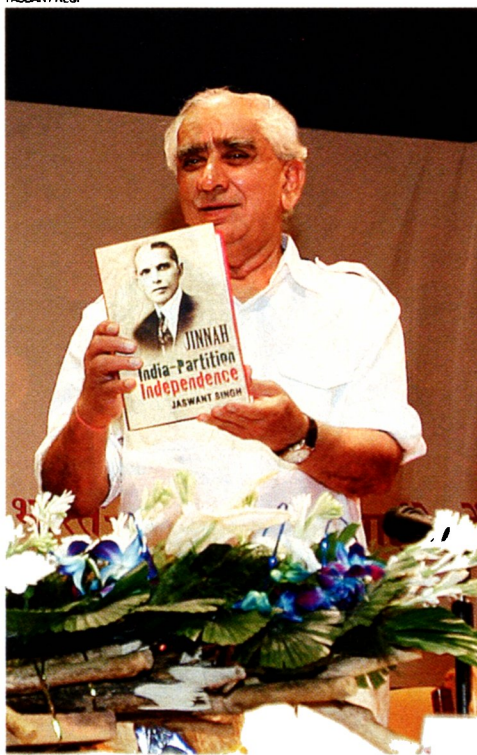


DELHI | Watch and Bait

Curioser and curioser: the BJP tying itself in knots expelling Jaswant Singh for his implicit criticism of party pin-up Sardar Patel and the Congress surprisingly silent about the equally critical treatment meted to their perennial icon, Jawaharlal Nehru. Reacting to Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi's ban of Singh's book *Jinnah: India-Partition-Independence*, the Congress took the moral high ground, saying that it was committed to freedom of speech. Instead, the Congress concentrated on scoffing at the BJP. Spokesperson Abhishek Singhvi said that while the Congress had only rejected the contents, the BJP had rejected the author himself. When asked to explain their somewhat muted reaction, spokesperson Manish Tiwari pointed out, "We did not consider it appropriate to dignify Mr Jaswant Singh's distortion of history with a reaction." Too busy enjoying the saffron side-show, the Congress has decided to sit this out and just watch the BJP conduct a rather public and very embarrassing book review. **by Priya Sahgal**

YASBANT NEGI



SINGH'S BOOK LAUNCHED HIM OUT OF THE BJP

Battle Ready

The Congress and the BJP are preparing for a head-to-head fight in three of the four states slated to go to polls soon. The BJP reckons if it wins two of these, i.e. manages the impossible, then it can claim that its fortunes have turned around.



GEHLOT (LEFT) MEETS SREEDHARAN

JAIPUR | Right On Track

During his earlier tenure as Rajasthan chief minister in 2003, Ashok Gehlot had rubbished the idea of a metro for Jaipur, saying that the state government was cash-starved. Last week he played host to Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) chief E. Sreedharan, promising him priority so that work can begin on the Jaipur Metro in March 2010. The Pink City's metro is scheduled to start running in 2013, the year the state goes to the polls. Gehlot is also willing to hand over the Rs 5,300-crore project to DMRC on a turnkey basis. He has also announced the setting up of the Jaipur Metro Corporation, which will oversee 28.5 km of track. **by Rohit Parihar**

S R I N A G A R | Militant Muddle

His escape was as dramatic as his arrest. Nissar Ahmad Bhat alias Gazi Misbah-u-Din, the operations head of Kashmir's largest militant group the Hizbul Mujahideen, has given the law the slip again. This while right under their noses, being presented before the Anantnag district court. The local police first tried to pass off Gazi's audacious escape as his "release on bail". They claimed that the militant was "released in open court and handed over to his lawyer". Official sources say he escaped just after his bail was granted by the court. Counter-intelligence sleuths who were waiting to rearrest Gazi were stunned when they found him gone. At least five policemen have been suspended and a high-level inquiry has been ordered into the meticulously planned escape. Two years ago, Gazi was arrested in a Bollywood-style thriller in Srinagar. His arrest was described as a major success achieved through months of coordinated human and electronic surveillance. Gazi is known to have a "high organisational acumen" and "can rejuvenate the group's striking power", says a senior cop.

by Aijaz Hussain